

opinion has been adopted, as usual, by Fritzsche's successors; thus Schürer, Reuss, König, Zöckler, Lupton, Cornill ("ohne Zweifel griechisch geschrieben"), Guthe ("sicher griechisch"), Bertholet, and many others. Most of these, it should be noted, make an exception of the passage 5:1-6, which (like Fritzsche) they believe to have been translated from a Hebrew original. Howorth asserts that the story was written in a "Semitic" language (of course, his theory of the book requires this), but does not attempt to go farther. Ball, in his notes in *The Variorum Apocrypha* (1892), suggested one or two hebraisms in these chapters, but did not thereby make a Semitic original seem probable. Renan (*Hist. du peuple d'Israel*, IV, p. 180, note) said, in speaking of I Esdr., chaps. 3 and 4: "The original was certainly Hebrew."

As for the Greek in which I Esdr. 3:1-5:6 now stands, those who believe it to be more idiomatic than the ordinary "translation Greek" of the Old Testament are mistaken. It stands, in this regard, on exactly the same plane as the old Greek version of Daniel, or that of the books of the Kings, or of First Maccabees. From the beginning to the end, it shows an unbroken succession of Semitic idioms, reproduced with a faithfulness which is often very clumsy, and in several cases giving plain evidence of mis-translation. It is true that the subject-matter (namely, in the section 3:18-4:32) is unlike anything else in the Old Testament; and it is this fact, unquestionably, which misled Fritzsche into making his extraordinary remark about the language of the document. But if any student of the Greek Bible will look closely at the idiom of these two chapters, he will find it precisely the same which elsewhere results from a close rendering of a Hebrew or Aramaic original. Again, though as regards subject-matter and mode of treatment the section just named happens to stand alone in our Old Testament literature, it is by no means true that it has a "Hellenistic" sound. All those who are familiar with Semitic modes of thought and literary forms will recognize here a characteristic Semitic product.

The fact must not be overlooked, that the first six verses of chap. 5 are almost universally pronounced a translation from a Semitic original, as above noted. The fact usually *is* overlooked. Those who make the exception straightway forget it, and certainly never attempt to explain it. On what theory can this translated